

Vedant Sundar

22 November 2024

Characterizing The Comic and Tragic Heroes, Presented in *Antigone* and *The Tempest*

Sophocles' tragedy *Antigone* and Shakespeare's tragicomedy *The Tempest* both recount a tale of suffering to introduce different morals through characterization. *Antigone* remains true to Aristotelian tragedy by pitting two larger-than-life personas: Creon, representing order without humanity, versus Antigone, humanity without order. By burying her brother, the traitor Polyneices, Antigone gains the ire of Creon, who repeatedly uses the state's authority to set things "right" — which eventually blurs the line between justice and abuse of power. *The Tempest*, on the other hand, falls more in line with Aristotelian comedy by depicting Prospero as a conflicting blend of humanity and tyrannical order, drawing out an inherently-flawed character. Prospero desires to regain his position as the Duke of Milan, once lost due to an injustice against him, by magically drawing his enemies to the island — only to forgive them in the end. Thus, the tragic hero is characterized as vindictive in stark contrast to the comic hero's characterization as sympathetic, implying an overall star-crossed nature for the tragic hero and a fortunate nature for the comic hero.

In *Antigone*, Creon is depicted as the tragic hero in that he possesses a vengeful attitude and ill-fated nature. When Haemon goes against Creon and stands up for Antigone, Creon states, "Never will I approve of one who breaks / And violates the law" (Kitto 664-665), leading to Haemon's declaration that Creon shall never "see [his] face again" (Kitto 763). Evidently, Creon's obsession with exacting revenge on Antigone backfires by causing the rather extreme loss of his own son. Moreover, Creon's staunch belief that the law presides over family initiates the anagnorisis by allowing Creon to reflect on his actions, facilitating a gradual shift in Creon's

character that enhances the impact of the tragedy. In addition, when Creon attempts to amend his mistakes by declaring, “I who imprisoned her will set her free” (Kitto 1112), it is revealed that Antigone, Haemon, and Creon’s wife Eurydice are all dead, leaving Creon to cry, “[w]hat else can Fate hold in store?” (Kitto 1297). While Creon tries to reform, fate is against him as his efforts never come to fruition, revealing that Creon is destined to fail regardless of his efforts to fix his mistakes. Furthermore, the peripeteia of the tragedy is initiated, which provides the reader, through Creon’s suffering, with the moral that hubris can lead to one’s downfall. Thus, throughout the tragedy, Creon is characterized as the tragic hero through his vindictive nature, which leads to his ever-so-magnificent failures that portray the tragic hero as ill-fated.

Contrastingly, Prospero, the comic hero of *The Tempest*, is depicted as sympathetic and fortunate. When Ariel remarks that Prospero might lash out in revenge when he sees his enemies, Prospero replies that, although he was exiled for twelve years, he will follow the “nobler reason ‘gainst [his] fury”, for “[t]he rarer action is / In virtue than in vengeance” (Shakespeare 5:1 33-35). Thus, even though Prospero has good reason to seek revenge, he chooses sympathy by forgiving his enemies. Hence, the once short-tempered Prospero has finally overcome the human foible of hastiness, as evidenced by his ability to think about the best moral decision before acting upon it. In contrast with Creon, Prospero is now aided by fate. Indeed, when Miranda confronts Prospero about his reason behind conjuring the tempest, Prospero states that it was “[b]y accident” that the “most strange, bountiful Fortune, / Now [...] hath mine enemies / Brought to this shore” (Shakespeare 1:2 212-214). Prospero’s encounter with his enemies after twelve years of isolation highlights Prospero’s fortune, with the word ‘bountiful’ implying that Prospero was so fortunate that all his enemies happened to be on the ship, not just a couple of them. Moreover, by explaining his story and rationale for his actions to Miranda, Prospero

invokes a sense of pity and false justice to validate his actions while making Miranda a puppet in his goal, which sets Prospero neither as morally correct nor incorrect and hence portrays Prospero in a lesser light than the noble characters of Aristotelian tragedy. Thus, throughout the comedy, Prospero is characterized as the comic hero through sympathy and fortune.

The conflicting characterizations of Creon and Prospero are further made clear by their differing reactions to their authority being challenged. In *Antigone*, although Creon is faced with Antigone's resistance to his prevention of Polyneices' burial, he refuses to be flexible and even goes on to state, "there is / No greater curse than disobedience" (Kitto 671-672). Hence, it is cemented early on that Creon refuses to renounce his order — the very element that gave him authority — even until the end, when no peace is left for the characters of the tragedy. Moreover, one can observe that Sophocles uses Creon's stubbornness and rigidity to further the theme of revenge destroying oneself. A similar scene is found in *The Tempest*, when Prospero realizes that his isolation is caused by his use of sorcery to exact revenge on those who oppose his unnatural authority. However, while Creon chose to remain obstinate towards any attempt to revoke his authority, Prospero chooses to forgo his revenge and authority when he remarks, "this rough magic / I here abjure" (Shakespeare 5:1 59-60). Prospero's flexibility not only portrays him as sympathetic but also draws out the motif of obedience to the natural order as Prospero renounces his artificial authority of sorcery — a motif starkly reversed in Creon's case, where his disobedience to the natural order causes tragedy for the entire society. Thus, when faced with opposition towards authority, Creon's rigidity leads him down a path of revenge and opposition to a natural order, whereas Prospero's flexibility portrays him as sympathetic and adhering to a natural order, contrasting the tragedy of Creon's kingdom with Prospero's peaceful ending via the motif of obedience.

In essence, the characterizations of the tragic and comic heroes reveal that heroes are still bound by human nature — the inescapable duality between ‘good’ and ‘bad.’ Modern psychology describes the totality of humans through psychoanalyst Carl Jung’s words: “the brighter the light, the darker the shadow.” Indeed, the collapse of Creon’s kingdom was incited by the clash between Creon and Antigone, caused by both embodying contrasting ideals — lights — without regard for their stubbornness — shadows — destroying society. Moreover, Creon’s overall depiction provides the reader with the motif of natural order being a karmic law: that correcting oneself after relentlessly aiming for vengeance only pits one against their pre-disposed fate. Prospero’s depiction supplements this motif in the converse sense, as sympathy and forgiveness can yield good fortune. Furthermore, Prospero’s acknowledgement of both his humanity and tyranny showcases his humanness as a hero and provides the theme that one must balance the duality in self to achieve their goals, unlike Creon’s overly-‘lawful’ disposition. Ergo, the tragic hero can be generalized as star-crossed and the comic hero as fortunate through their respective vindictive and sympathetic natures.

Works Cited

Shakespeare, William. *The Tempest*. Edited by Barbara A. Mowat and Paul Werstine, Paperback ed., New York, Simon & Schuster, 2009.

Sophocles. *Antigone, Oedipus the King and Electra*. Edited by Edith Hall, translated by H. D. F. Kitto, New York, Oxford University Press, 2008.